

ESSAY 05

A Short Case for Boring Output

Why the same page, over and over, beats visual variety when the goal is to be read.

Most document generators optimize for **visual variety** — icons, gradients, accent palettes, rounded corners, illustrated divider graphics. This one does not. It aims to produce the same kind of page, over and over, with as little chrome as the content will tolerate. The reference points, if any, are the Manutius pocket editions, the Penguin Rules of Composition, and the long shelf of technical manuals that quietly just work.

WHY

The point of a printed page is **to be read**.

- Every extra color is a decision the reader has to resolve.
- Every rounded corner is a style choice the reader has to *accept or ignore*.
- Every shadow is an attempt to imitate paper that paper itself does not need.

When those decisions aren't yours to make, the reader can just read. See The Elements of Typographic Style for the long version of this argument — or the much shorter version in Matthew Butterick's Typography for Lawyers.

WHAT YOU GET

Element	Treatment
H1	IBM Plex Serif 700, ink-black, double rule below
H2–H4	Same serif family, tighter hierarchy
Body	Lora 10.5pt, 1.46 leading, true-italic for emphasis
Code	Warm off-white panel, mono, language tag top-right
Tables	Uppercase-mono header, no vertical borders
Links	Ink-black, underlined
Callouts	Three voices: note (plain), warn (rule), system (mono)
Header	Section · Title · Date in IBM Plex Serif, uppercase
Footer	<code>page / total</code> in mono, centered

HOW

1. Extract frontmatter with `gray-matter`.

2. Parse Markdown to an mdast tree (`remark-parse` + `remark-gfm`).
3. Transform mdast $\rightarrow$ hast with `remark-rehype`, running a small `remarkCallouts` plugin along the way.
4. Syntax-highlight with `@shikijs/rehype` using a grayscale theme.
5. Stringify to HTML, wrap in a minimal shell, drive Chromium through Playwright, emit the PDF.

Nothing in that list is novel. The novelty, if any, is in what's left out.

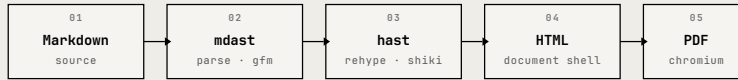


Fig. 1 The five stages the pipeline passes through, from Markdown source to printed PDF.

CODE, FOR FLAVOR

```

const { content, frontmatter } = extractFrontmatter(raw);
const resolved = resolveOptions({ cli, frontmatter, project });
const tree = parseMarkdownToMdast(content);
const body = await mdastToHtml(tree);
const html = wrapInDocumentShell(body, {
  title: resolved.title ?? deriveTitle(inputPath),
  baseUrl: pathToFileURL(dirname(inputPath) + "/").href,
});
  
```

One call per stage. No theme registry, no plugin API — if a second output format ever arrives, we can add one then.

CALLOUTS

Three types, one source format — a `[!NOTE]`, `[!WARN]`, or `[!SYSTEM]` tag on the first line of a blockquote.

[!NOTE] Useful context that isn't load-bearing. A quiet aside the reader can take or leave.

[!WARN] Something the reader must not miss. The left rule is enough signal; the tag above it is enough name.

[!SYSTEM] A diagnostic, an engineering invariant, or a pre-condition. The mono face and the dashed rule together read as “from the machine, not the author” — without needing a label to say so.

A NOTE ON CHECKLISTS

- ☒ Five accent palettes.
- ☒ Grayscale only — no accent color.
- ☒ Header and footer in the same typographic voice.
- ☒ Cover page with suppressed running header on page 1.

- ☐ Table of contents with real page numbers (next).

The strikethrough, task list, and nested list all render from a single Markdown source — no special syntax, no escape hatches.

CLOSING

Design is a plan for arranging elements in such a way as best to accomplish a particular purpose.

— Charles Eames, who knew a thing or two about chairs.

If a boring page is readable, and a readable page gets read, the boring page has out-performed the interesting one. That is the whole case.